

CHAPTER 4

The Color of Congress: The Impact of Race and the Role of Issues in Congressional Roll Call Votes

It is common knowledge that the history of American politics began with coalitions based on common interests involving economic, social, religious, and ethnic groups. In this context, the Congressional Black Caucus is not a maverick organization. . . . We are, therefore, interested in developing, introducing, and passing progressive legislation which will meet the needs of millions of neglected citizens.

—Congressman Louis Stokes, Congressional Black Caucus

It would be rare to find a social group whose members would not feel deprived if someone like themselves were not included in the representative assembly. The social composition of a representative body is important from a symbolic perspective because it demonstrates to groups in society that they are taken seriously by the government. Sociological similarity (descriptive representation) helps to promote good representation and political stability by increasing members of the group's faith and trust in government (symbolic representation).¹ Beyond the symbolic rewards a social group may receive from having someone like themselves in elective office, there should also be real and tangible policy benefits from increasing the group's representation in the assembly. The presumption is that representatives who share their constituents' sociological characteristics will work hard to speak for constituents' views and serve their constituents' interests in the governmental process. But is there a relationship between descriptive representation and substantive representation? In other words, is the quality of substantive representation for African-Americans affected by the racial composition within the congressional delegation? Or, bluntly put, does race really matter in congressional voting on black policy preferences? In view of the continuing controversy over racial redistricting to increase black congressional representation to better serve the policy interests of the black community, the issue of race takes on both political and legal significance.

The purpose of this chapter is threefold: first, to develop a theory for understanding the connection between race and legislator behavior; second, to determine whether race makes a difference in explaining black policy preferences; and, third, to take a closer look at the relevance of issues in congressional voting behavior on this important subject.

Theoretical Considerations

The extant literature on legislative elections and representation has paid little attention to the possible theoretical connection between the race of the legislator and the quality of representation that African-Americans will receive. The theoretical evidence that does exist in the larger literature on representation leads one to suspect that the race of the representative does not make a difference concerning matters of public policy. Hanna Pitkin, in her influential work on representation, defines political representation principally in substantive terms.² Likewise, Heinz Eulau and Paul Karps view other forms of representation as being less important than that of substantive representation.³ David Vogler sums up the conventional view of the possible link between descriptive and substantive representation: "Sometimes background characteristics do influence a legislator's vote, but often they are of no relevance in explaining congressional behavior."⁴

Implicit in the theoretical literature on representation is the notion that representatives should be judged in terms of their legislative activities, not on the extent to which they mirror the social traits of the people they formally represent. From the perspective of traditional theory the race of the member ought *not* to affect his or her policy-making behavior. At first glance the theoretical evidence for hypothesizing that a relationship exists between race and representation is weak. Yet there is an alternative theoretical perspective grounded in the literature on group consciousness, the social psychology of race, and House members' political perceptions of their constituencies that points toward a different view of the race-representation connection.

Richard L. Hall and Colleen Heflin offer a theory concerning the relationship between racial group identification and minority substantive representation in Congress.⁵ This theory is based on the proposition that historically blacks have been one of the most deprived and most discriminated-against groups in the United States. As discussed in the previous chapter, more subtle manifestations of racial discrimination appear to have replaced overt discriminatory laws and practices. Moreover, while integration has made some progress in the United States, race continues to be a major force shaping the lives of blacks. The economic deprivation and social isolation of blacks continue to be major features of the American political landscape. According to researchers who have analyzed the role of race from the standpoint of group consciousness, there should be a strong feeling of group attachment among African-Americans. Even though blacks are not monolithic in the political views they hold, these strong feelings of racial group identification should run deep within the African-American community and play a major role in determining how they view the political world. A sense of group consciousness should penetrate beyond the boundaries of the political behavior of the black masses (e.g., voting for party candidates) into the behavior of black political elites. Based on the socially constructed view of black elite attitudes, Hall and Heflin suggest that the policy interests of the black masses will be reflected in the legislative work of black representatives because of their common bond, resulting from shared past and present experiences.⁶

Michael Dawson, in *Behind the Mule: Race and Class in African-American Politics*, develops a theory that goes further to show that the psychology of social groups is critical in explaining group solidarity among African-Americans. Dawson's theory (termed *black utility heuristic*) places emphasis on perceptions of "linked fates" (perceived link between racial group interests and individual interests) and black economic subordination. That is, the social and economic opportunities of most African-Americans are so inextricably tied to being black that it is only rational for them to see racial group interests as a proxy for their individual interests. Thus, most blacks use racial group interests as a means by which they evaluate political candidates, political parties, and public policies. Furthermore, according to the author, the notion of linked fates transcends the boundaries of economic status within the black community. As suggested by Hall and Heflin (1994), this theory leads one to believe that the vast majority of black members of Congress will have a strong sense of racial identity, which will lead them to support policies of interest to black constituents. In some sense a spontaneous form of representation will emerge because of the development of a unique racial consciousness and belief system that makes black representatives predisposed to vote the way most blacks in the district would want the legislator to vote anyway. In essence their support for black policy preferences should be unparalleled in Congress because what's in the best interest of the black masses is also in the best interest of black policymakers.⁷

African-Americans, other minority group members, and women argue that their interests would be better served by increasing their representation in Congress. More specifically, civil rights advocates maintain that there is a need to increase black membership in Congress because there are many important issues that run along racial lines. Moreover, too often in the past elected officials have overlooked and disregarded the needs and concerns of African-Americans to the predictable end that blacks have been deprived of adequate representation. Once in office, civil rights proponents contend, African-Americans would be in a better position to place civil rights issues higher on the national political agenda to help fight continuing discrimination against people of color.

Implicit in the literature on the role of group consciousness is the assumption that black representatives will work diligently to improve the quality of substantive representation for fellow group members. Simply stated, there should be a strong link between descriptive and substantive representation. Undoubtedly, this was one of the major reasons for organizing the Congressional Black Caucus (CBC) in 1969. As one black representative who helped to organize the CBC states, "protecting black interests was the primary reason most of us were elected."⁸

The final line of theoretical reasoning focuses on the electoral link between the constituency and the political perceptions of the representative. This theoretical construction is based on the following question: Who does the representative think him- or herself responsive to on matters of public policy? The answer, to a large degree, lies in the member's own perception of the people who he or she thinks will provide the electoral support needed to win a seat in Congress. The importance of the electoral environment has been discussed throughout this book and extensively in the literature on congressional representation. Aside from the work of Hall and Heflin, however, the theoretical basis for linking black constituents to the political perceptions of the representative has received little attention. Hall and Heflin derive the theoretical foundation for hypothesizing the importance of such a relationship from the work of Richard Fenno, invoking his oft-cited passage in the introduction to *Home Style*. His study of eighteen House members at home in their districts led him to the following observations about their political perceptions of constituents:

One question central to the representative-constituency relationship remains underdeveloped. It is: *What does an elected representative see when he or she sees a constituency?* And as a natural follow up, *What consequences do these perceptions have for his or her behavior?* The key problem is perception. And the key assumption is that the constituency a representative reacts to is the constituency he or she sees.⁹

The fundamental question Hall and Heflin derive from Fenno's observation is this: Is the correspondence between white representatives and their black constituents the same as it is for black representatives and their constituents? If the assumption can be made that a member's perception of the district is affected by his or her electoral needs, then it is believed that the answer is no. All things considered, black candidates need greater numbers of black votes to win a House seat than do white candidates. Hall and Heflin also call attention to Fenno's report of an exchange between a white congressman and his district staffer who were riding through a black neighborhood of a city. Fenno listened to the following exchange between the congressman and his staff member:

Congressman: I concede the black vote.

Staffer: I wouldn't want to be out there walking on the sidewalk.

Congressman: It's like some Caribbean country.

Staffer: It sure is a different country here.

To be sure, this is the view of only one representative and does not reflect the sentiments of all white lawmakers who represent multiracial districts. But this exchange suggests that, unlike the vast majority of black candidates, many white candidates do not have to rely heavily on the black vote to win a House seat. Black congressional candidates can ill afford to concede the black vote and expect to win a congressional race. Because of their greater need for black electoral support, the representational link between black representatives and their black constituents should be closer than the connection between white representatives and their black constituents. One possible consequence of this development is that black lawmakers will be more responsive to black policy preferences than white because they see black voters as a vital component of their electoral base, all things being equal.

Taken together, these factors provide a strong theoretical basis for hypothesizing that the race of the member will significantly affect the quality of substantive representation for African-Americans. As stated earlier, empirical investigation on the subject matter is virtually nonexistent. Recent findings, however, cast a shadow of doubt on whether race really matters in congressional roll calls on black policy preferences. Carol Swain, in her book *Black Faces, Black Interests: The Representation of African Americans in Congress*, finds little evidence that race impacts a legislator's substantive representation of black interests once the representative's party and regional affiliation are entered into the equation.¹⁰ While the author acknowledges that her findings may not be generalized beyond her examination of the 100th Congress, nonetheless, the conclusions have profound implications for those wishing to improve the voice of historically underrepresented groups in society and for those who may wish to de-emphasize the significance of their membership in the legislature.

The purpose here is to conduct a thorough investigation to see if race makes a difference in the voting decisions of members of the House on civil rights-related issues. Before doing so, it would be useful to give a brief overview of the history and current status of black congressional representation as well as the extant literature on white legislator responsiveness to black constituents. The focus then shifts to an analysis of the role of race and issues in congressional roll calls.

The Status of Black Congressional Representation

Congress has never been a sociological microcosm of the United States' population. Throughout the nation's history it has been a haven for white males. In all our history only ninety-nine blacks (1870–1997) have served in Congress, four of them in the Senate and the rest in the House.¹¹ Nearly one-third of them served during the Reconstruction era. During the post—Civil War period all black members of Congress were Republicans, loyal to the party of Abraham Lincoln. There were no blacks serving in Congress from 1901 to 1928. In 1928 Oscar DePriest, a Republican from the state of Illinois, was the first black to serve in Congress during the twentieth century. Only four more blacks entered Congress before 1960 (Arthur W. Mitchell, Illinois; William L. Dawson, Illinois; Adam C. Powell Jr., New York; and Charles C. Diggs Jr., Michigan). In the years following the New Deal all but three blacks (Senator Edward W. Brooke of Massachusetts and Representatives Gary Franks of Connecticut and J. C. Watts of Oklahoma) have been Democrats.

Blacks have increased their congressional representation somewhat in the past three decades primarily due to the Voting Rights Act of 1965 and its extensions. In 1972 Barbara Jordan of Texas and Andrew Young of Georgia were the first blacks elected in the South since 1900. Judicial interpretation of the act, as amended in 1982, brought additional black gains in Congress. Court rulings mandated gerrymandering to maximize black voting strength, which in turn created greater opportunities for black voters to elect representatives of their choice. As a result, black membership in the House grew to over twenty members during the 1980s. Racial gerrymandering after the 1990 census led to the creation of twelve new black majority districts. For the first time since Reconstruction blacks were elected to Congress from Alabama, Florida, North Carolina, South Carolina, and Virginia. In 1992 thirty-nine members and one senator (Carol Mosely-Braun, Illinois) were elected to serve in the 103d Congress. In 1994 thirty-nine African-Americans were elected to serve in the House in the 104th Congress. In proportional terms blacks who make up 12 percent of the nation's population represented 9 percent of the House membership in the 103d and 104th Congresses. After the 1996 elections thirty-nine African-Americans were elected to serve (including nonvoting delegates) in the House in the 105th Congress. They represent approximately 9.0 percent of the membership in the House. A list of all black members of Congress serving throughout history to the present can be seen in [table 11](#).

Despite black gains in Congress, the proportion of their membership in Congress remains below the proportion of African-Americans in the general black population. Black gains in Congress may be tenuous because the gerrymandering necessary to achieve black majority districts is being challenged in the courts. As shall be demonstrated in the next chapter, few blacks have been successful in winning congressional seats in white majority districts.¹² And, unless they are able to do so, future black gains in Congress may be short-lived.¹³

Past Research on White Congressional Responsiveness to Black Interests

Most research on legislator responsiveness to black policy interests has focused on the South, where blacks have faced the most resistance to their political participation. There is little doubt that the engine of change in the region has been the increase in black voter participation. As part of their strategy to win elective office, some white representatives have found it to be politically expedient to become more responsive to black interests. As discussed earlier, researchers are less certain about the exact nature of the relationship but agree that black voter participation has caused many southern House members to moderate their conservative policy views on racial issues.¹⁴ A study by Kenny Whitby and Franklin Gilliam Jr. also found behavioral change occurring among southern white congressional Democrats over time. After analyzing the voting records of southern House members over a twenty-year period, it found a trend toward less conservative voting taking place in southern Democrats' voting behavior. The study also found that greater policy responsiveness from these legislators was due in part to the mobilization and participation of the southern black electorate.¹⁵ The effects of black voter participation on white legislator responsiveness can also be interactive; that is, less conservative voting is in part caused by the interaction between the constituency variables race and urbanization.¹⁶

It should come as no surprise that past studies have found that partisanship plays a major role in congressional roll call voting on civil rights legislation.¹⁷ Research on the impact of party has focused on both the South and the total membership of

the House. Research reveals that partisanship is an important predictor of liberal voting.¹⁸ Furthermore, according to previous findings, the predictive power of party has increased over time as a consequence of southern Democrats voting more like their party colleagues from the non-South.¹⁹

TABLE 11. African-American Members in Congress by Party, State, Year, and Congress, 1870–1997

Name	Party	State	Year	Congress
<i>Senate</i>				
Hiram R. Revels	R	Mississippi	1870–71	41st
Blanche K. Bruce	R	Mississippi	1875–81	44th–45th
Edward W. Brooke	R	Massachusetts	1967–79	90th–95th
Carol Mosely-Braun	D	Illinois	1993–	103d–
<i>House</i>				
Joseph H. Rainey	R	South Carolina	1870–79	41st–45th
Jefferson F. Long	R	Georgia	1870–71	41st
Robert B. Elliot	R	South Carolina	1871–74	42d–43d
Robert C. DeLarge	R	South Carolina	1871–73	42d
Benjamin S. Turner	R	Alabama	1871–73	42d
Josiah T. Walls	R	Florida	1871–76	42d–44th
Richard H. Cain	R	South Carolina	1873–75	43d–45th
John R. Lynch	R	Mississippi	1877–79	43d–45th
			1873–77	43d–47th
James T. Rapier	R	Alabama	1882–83	43d
			1873–75	43d
Alonzo J. Ransier	R	South Carolina	1873–75	43d
Jeremiah Haralson	R	Alabama	1875–77	44th
John A. Hyman	R	North Carolina	1875–77	44th
Charles E. Nash	R	Louisiana	1875–77	44th
Robert Smalls	R	South Carolina	1875–79	45th
James E. O'Hara	R	North Carolina	1882–83	47th–49th
			1884–87	51st–52d
Henry P. Cheatham	R	North Carolina	1889–93	51st–52d
John M. Langston	R	Virginia	1890–91	51st
Thomasa E. Miller	R	South Carolina	1890–91	51st
George W. Murray	R	South Carolina	1893–95	53d–54th
George H. White	R	North Carolina	1886–97	55th–56th
			1897–1901	71st–73d
Oscar DePriest	R	Illinois	1929–35	74th–77th
Arthur W. Mitchell	D	Illinois	1935–43	78th–91st
William L. Dawson	D	Illinois	1943–70	79th–90th
Adam C. Powell Jr.	D	New York	1945–67	91st
Charles C. Diggs Jr.	D	Michigan	1969–71	84th–96th
Robert C. Nix Sr.	D	Pennsylvania	1955–80	85th–95th
Augustus F. Hawkins	D	California	1959–79	88th–101st
John Conyers Jr.	D	Michigan	1963–90	89th–
Louis Stokes	D	Ohio	1965–	91st–
William L. Clay	D	Missouri	1969–	91st–
Shirley Chisholm	D	New York	1969–83	91st–97th
George W. Collins	D	Illinois	1970–72	91st–92d
Ronald Dellums	D	California	1971–	92d–

Walter E. Fauntroy ^a	D	Washington, D.C.	1971–90	92d–101st
Ralph H. Metcalf	D	Illinois	1971–78	92d–95th
Parren J. Mitchell	D	Maryland	1971–87	92d–99th
Charles B. Rangel	D	New York	1971–	92d–
Yvonne B. Burke	D	California	1973–79	93d–95th
Cardis Collins	D	Illinois	1973–96	92d–104th
Barbara C. Jordan	D	Texas	1973–79	93d–95th
Andrew Young	D	Georgia	1973–77	93d–95th
Harold E. Ford	D	Tennessee	1975–96	94th–104th
Julian C. Dixon	D	California	1979–	96th–
William H. Gray III	D	Pennsylvania	1979–91	96th–102d
George T. Leland	D	Texas	1979–89	96th–101st
Bennett M. Stewart	D	Illinois	1979–81	96th
George Crockett Jr.	D	Michigan	1981–92	96th–102d
Mervyn M. Dymally	D	California	1981–92	97th–102d
Gus Savage	D	Illinois	1981–92	97th–102d
Harold Washington	D	Illinois	1981–83	97th–98th
Katie Hall	D	Indiana	1983–85	97th–98th
Charles A. Hayes	D	Illinois	1983–92	98th–102d
Major R. Owens	D	New York	1983–	98th–
Edolphus Towns	D	New York	1983–	98th–
Alan Wheat	D	Missouri	1983–94	98th–103d
Alton R. Walton Jr.	D	New York	1986–87	99th
Mike Espy	D	Mississippi	1987–93	100th–103d
Floyd Flake	D	New York	1987–	100th–
John Lewis	D	Georgia	1987–	100th–
Kweisi Mfume	D	Maryland	1987–96	100th–104th
Donald M. Payne	D	New Jersey	1989–	101st–
Craig Washington	D	Texas	1990–94	101st–103d
Eleanor H. Norton ^a	D	Washington, D.C.	1991–	102d–
Maxine Waters	D	California	1991–	102d–
Gary Franks	R	Connecticut	1991–96	102d–104th
William Jefferson	D	Louisiana	1991–	102d–
Barbara Rose-Collins	D	Michigan	1991–96	102d–104th
Lucien E. Blackwell	D	Pennsylvania	1991–94	102d–103d
Earl F. Hilliard	D	Alabama	1993–	103d–
Walter R. Tucker	D	California	1993–95	103d–104th
Corrine Brown	D	Florida	1993–	103d–
Carrie Meek	D	Florida	1993–	103d–
Alcee L. Hastings	D	Florida	1993–	103d–
Sanford Bishop	D	Georgia	1993–	103d–
Cynthia McKinney	D	Georgia	1993–	103d–
Bobby L. Rush	D	Illinois	1993–	103d–
Mel Reynolds	D	Illinois	1993–95	103d–104th
Cleo Fields	D	Louisiana	1993–96	103d–104th
Albert R. Wynn	D	Maryland	1993–	103d–

Eva M. Clayton	D	North Carolina	1993–	103d–
Melvin L. Watt	D	North Carolina	1993–	103d–
James E. Clyburn	D	South Carolina	1993–	103d–
Eddie B. Johnson	D	Texas	1993–	103d–
Robert C. Scott	D	Virginia	1993–	103d–
Bennie G. Thompson	D	Mississippi	1993–	103d–
Chaka Fattah	D	Pennsylvania	1995–	104th–
Sheila J. Lee	D	Texas	1995–	104th–
J. C. Watts	R	Oklahoma	1995–	104th–
Jesse Jackson Jr.	D	Illinois	1995–	104th–
Elijah E. Cummings	D	Maryland	1996–	104th–
Juanita Millender McDonald	D	California	1996–	104th–
Julia M. Carson	D	Indiana	1996–	105th–
Danny Davis	D	Illinois	1996–	105th–
Harold Ford Jr.	D	Tennessee	1996–	105th–
Carolyn Kilpatrick	D	Michigan	1996–	105th–

Sources: Congressional Quarterly Weekly Report 49 (January 2, 1993), 10; Michael Barone and Grant Ujifusa, The Almanac of American Politics, 1996 (Washington, D.C.: National Journal, 1995); New York Times (November 7, 1996).

^aNonvoting delegate.

It is undoubtedly true that party identification plays a major role in explaining the behavior of members on issues related to race. But is the impact of party so strong that race is an insignificant predictor of legislator behavior on black policy preferences? On the one hand, we have observed in this research that Democrats, especially nonsouthern Democrats, are supporters of black interest legislation. But, on the other hand, the findings show that some Democrats are reluctant to support civil rights legislation, especially during the amending process. Swain's analysis suggests that race matters little in explaining substantive representation for African-Americans primarily because of the influence of party. There is research to suggest otherwise. Empirical evidence can be found in Hall and Heflin's examination of the relationship between race and legislative voting behavior in the 101st and 102d Congress. In a study of elite attitudes Sidney Verba and Gary Orren find that, on equality issues, African-Americans are much more likely to be to the Left of other major social groups. Moreover, according to their research findings, black leaders also hold consistently more liberal views than other white Democratic leaders within the party's coalition.²⁰ There are theoretical reasons to suspect that the behavioral patterns exhibited by party leaders can manifest themselves in the voting patterns of members of Congress.

The Significance of Color in Congress

To investigate the dyadic relationship between race and representatives' policy views on black interest legislation, the roll call voting behavior of House members spanning a twenty-year time period (93d through 103d Congresses) is examined. The lengthy time period is needed because the content of civil rights bills vary from Congress to Congress. Furthermore, the analysis is comprehensive so that safe conclusions can be stated about the impact of race. To increase the small number of cases for black members and to lessen problems associated with redistricting, the research in this section is divided into four time periods: time period 1 = members serving in 1973–76 (93d–94th Congresses); time period 2 = representatives serving in 1977–82 (95th–97th Congresses); time period 3 = legislators serving in 1983–86 (98th–99th Congresses), and time period 4 = legislators serving in 1987–92 (100th–102d Congresses). Conducting the analysis in this manner also has the advantage of increasing the number of amendments and final roll calls.²¹ Because of the relatively high number of blacks serving in the 103d Congress and the fact that it was the only Congress for which data were available for this investigation after the 1990s round of redistricting, it will be closely examined in the next section on the relevance of issues.

Two models are constructed—one including legislative proposals during the amending process and one incorporating final roll call bills. It is hypothesized that race is a predictor of legislator support for black policy preferences and that its effect will be greater on amendments than on final passage bills. On average black members of Congress will support legislation beneficial to black constituents regardless of the stage of the roll call voting process. It is white representatives who face the difficult task of deciding whether to support or vote against strong civil rights measures.

Congressional ratings compiled by the LCCR are used as the dependent variable in the two models to measure the extent to which House members support black interest legislation.²² Civil rights bills cannot be used here to assess the behavior of representatives because they do not come up for consideration in every congress. As previously stated, in [chapter 1](#), the LCCR index is used on a regular basis by researchers to measure legislator support for progressive civil rights proposals. Since the LCCR index was first computed in the late 1960s, it has the added value of giving the researcher the opportunity to examine the behavior of representatives on race-relevant issues over an extended period of time. A possible problem in using the LCCR scores in a longitudinal study of this nature is issue variance. That is, legislators' LCCR scores may vary from Congress to Congress because the nature of the bills may differ from year to year. One solution to this potential problem is to

include only those members who serve from Congress to Congress in a chosen time period. Conducting the analysis in this fashion lessens the problems associated with issue variance by subjecting all members to the same issues and influences in a given time period.

Each of the two models considers five independent variables: political party, region, race of the member, the percentage of blacks in the district, and the percentage of urban residents. Unfortunately, high collinearity between the race of the member variable and the racial composition variable precludes a quantitative assessment of the complete model.²³ The high correlation between the two sets of independent variables is due to the fact that most black representatives come from districts with a large black population. The general problem with this strong statistical relationship between the percentage of blacks in the district and the representation of the district by a black lawmaker is that their parameter estimates are likely to be unreliable. Moreover, when high collinearity exists one runs the risk of accepting the null hypothesis when in fact there is a statistically significant relationship between the dependent and independent variables.²⁴ The prescription here is to drop one of the two independent variables from the model. Given the theoretical and substantive interest in this chapter on the race of the member, the decision here is to drop the proportion of blacks in district variable from the model.²⁵ Expressed in the form of an equation, the models take on the following forms:

$$Y = a + b_1X_1 + b_2X_2 + b_3X_3 + b_4b_4 + e \quad (3)$$

where:

Y is the House member's LCCR score on amendments ranging from 0 (most conservative) to 100 (most liberal); and in the final passage model Y is the legislator's LCCR policy support score on final decision bills, operationalized in the same manner as amendments.

a is the constant.

b_1 is the representative's political party affiliation, coded 1 if Democrat, 0 if Republican.

b_2 is the member's regional affiliation, coded 1 if a representative is from the non-South, 0 if from the South.²⁶

b_3 is the racial identity of the member, coded 1 if black, 0 if white.

b_4 is the proportion of the district that is urban

e is the error term.²⁷

The preceding considerations lead to the following expectations: $b_1 > 0$, $b_2 > 0$, $b_3 > 0$, and $b_4 > 0$; that is, the coefficient signs of party, region, race, and urbanization will be positive. It is also expected that each of the independent variables will have a statistically significant impact on policy responsiveness to black interests in both models. Ordinary least squares regression tests the impact of the explanatory variables.²⁸

The results of the regression analysis are reported in [tables 12](#) and [13](#). Unstandardized regression coefficients can be used to show the difference in mean policy support scores between blacks and whites, after the influences of party, region, and urbanization have been accounted for. The standardized regression coefficients (beta weights) are used to show the relative importance of the independent variable both cross-sectionally and across time periods.

Not surprisingly, party looms as the most important explanatory variable in the models. Mean support scores of Democrats are significantly different (.000 level) from the average support scores of Republicans, once the effects of region, race, and urbanization are controlled for. An examination of the unstandardized coefficients in the amendment model ([table 12](#)) reveals that differences in mean amendment scores between the two parties range from 40 percent (1973–76) to 52 percent (1983–86). Mean final roll call scores ([table 13](#)) range from 36 percent (1977–82) to 56 percent (1973–76). The findings clearly suggest that House Democrats, on average, are much more supportive of black interest legislation than are House Republicans. Moreover, as the standardized regression coefficients in both models show, the impact of party has grown over the two-decade period. Its weight ranges from .559 (1973–76) to .787 (1983–86) in the amendment model and varies from a low of .514 (1977–82) to a high of .755 (1987–92) in the final roll call model.

As hypothesized, region significantly influences (.000 level) the behavior of House members. But, as the strength of party has grown in recent years, the impact of region gradually weakens across time. Substantively, nonsouthern members continue to be more supportive of civil rights-related issues than their southern colleagues, but the gap among regional House members has declined. The drop in mean scores is about the same in both models, fluctuating between highs of 21 and 31 percent in the earliest time frame to lows of 11 and 15 percent in the more recent time periods. What the findings suggest is that party is becoming increasingly influential in explaining legislator support of black policy preferences, but regional differences do remain a factor. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965 have been major factors in narrowing policy differences between northern and southern Democrats and sharpening those between the Democrats and Republicans in Congress. The findings do not mean, however, that southern Democrats are as responsive to black interests as their party colleagues in the non-South. They do imply that the southern congressional wing of the party has been slowly moving in the direction of the mainstream of the party on class-based socioeconomic issues.²⁹

TABLE 12. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members' Support for Black Policy Preferences: Regression Estimates

Variables	Amendment Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1973-76 ^a			
93d-94th Congresses	40.256	.559	22.287***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	40.893	.610	31.188***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	52.422	.787	38.644***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	41.014	.744	42.022***
<i>Region (Non-south/South)</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	30.611	.379	14.891***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	22.475	.299	15.104***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	13.745	.185	9.149***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	13.734	.221	12.566***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	18.558	.097	3.863***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	16.404	.091	4.663***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	4.095	.024	1.157
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	5.010	.040	1.700*
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	.165	.110	4.240***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	.219	.156	7.688***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	.122	.083	4.015***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	.130	.108	5.957***

Note: Members' support as measured by the Leadership Conference on Civil Rights (LCCR). Members' LCCR scores range from 0 (most conservative) to 100 (most liberal).

^a1973-76 ($R^2 = .49$, $N = 861$); 1977-82 ($R^2 = .54$, $N = 1293$); 1983-86 ($R^2 = .67$, $N = 837$); 1987-92 ($R^2 = .64$, $N = 1214$).

*** $p \leq .001$ * $p \leq .10$ (one-tailed tests)

TABLE 13. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members' Support for Black Policy Preferences: Regression Estimates

Variables	Final Passage Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1973-76 ^a			
93d-94th Congresses	56.236	.671	29.321***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	36.031	.514	22.633***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	47.731	.720	30.173***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	42.414	.755	43.998***
<i>Region (Non-South/South)</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	26.261	.279	12.031***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	20.781	.264	11.503***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	10.539	.142	6.015***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	15.041	.237	13.923***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	6.811	.030	1.335
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	8.641	.045	2.000**
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	2.400	.014	.582
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	2.969	.023	1.289
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1973-76			
93d-94th Congresses	.292	.167	7.049***
1977-82			
95th-97th Congresses	.187	.128	5.436***
1983-86			
98th-99th Congresses	.096	.066	2.707***
1987-92			
100th-102d Congresses	.140	.113	6.485***

Note: Per LCCR index.

^a1973-76 ($R^2 = .57$); 1977-82 ($R^2 = .37$); 1983-86 ($R^2 = .55$); 1987-92 ($R^2 = .66$). See table 4.2 for *N* of cases.

*** $p \leq .001$ ** $p \leq .05$ (one-tailed tests)

As expected, the constituency variable urbanization also helps to account for variation in black policy preferences. It is statistically significant in each of the time periods in the analysis. The findings are consistent with what we have observed in earlier chapters; that is, while urbanization is a predictor of support for black policy preferences, its predictive power is not as strong as party or region.

The relationship of particular interest is between the race of the member and black policy preferences. There are several noteworthy findings that can be deduced from the summary statistics in the tables. First, even after controlling for the powerful effects of region and party, race significantly impacts the behavior of House members in a positive direction. This finding can be interpreted to mean that the racial identity of the member matters in congressional voting for progressive civil

rights proposals even when party and region are held constant. The difference in mean support scores between black and white legislators is approximately 9 percent (1977–82) in the final passage vote model, and average scores vary from 5 percent (1987–92) to 19 percent (1973–76) in the amendment vote model.

A second finding of note is that race has period effects. That is, based on the groupings of congresses for analysis, the average scores of black representatives in the 1983–86 time period in the amendment model are found not to differ significantly from the mean scores of their white colleagues. And, in the final passage vote model, the impact of race only shows up in the time period from 1977 to 1982. A more detailed explanation for the findings of period effects will follow in the next section. For now it suffices to note that the nature of the civil rights bills vary from Congress to Congress and can determine whether race will be a factor in explaining legislator responsiveness to black policy interests.

A third finding of interest is that the impact of race is stronger in the amendment model than in the final passage model. In each of the time periods in which race is found to be statistically significant, mean support scores are higher on roll call votes on amendments. The conclusion is that racial differences on black interest legislation are more likely to show up on roll calls during the amending process than on final passage.

Overall the goodness of fit in both models ranges in the low-moderate to high-moderate range. The major difference between the two models is the impact of race, whose effect is more pronounced on amendments than on final roll calls. The statistical analysis provides some evidence that race matters in representatives' voting decisions on civil rights-related issues. But the analysis does not tell us much about the actual conditions under which race is likely to be a significant predictor of civil rights support.

The Relative Importance of Issues

The main proposition here is that the saliency of race depends on the nature of the civil rights proposal being voted on by members of Congress. Civil rights bills vary in strength; some are controversial, and others are not. Civil rights bills that are relatively uncontroversial will produce roll calls that are unanimous or nearly unanimous in support or in opposition. They are weak tests of dimensionality—or, more specifically, support of black interest legislation—because they do not reveal anything about differences in issue positions among legislators. Even party, the strongest predictor of legislative voting on socioeconomic legislation, will not show up as a predictor of roll call voting behavior because of solid House support. Then there are civil rights proposals that produce cleavages along partisan lines—that is, unity within the Democratic or Republican Party for or against a bill. Here party becomes the major predictor of legislative behavior. Many civil rights bills do not produce racial cleavages because they are essentially moderate proposals designed to appeal to marginal supporters in the House. Finally, some civil rights proposals are controversial and are more likely to produce cleavages along racial lines in the House. These are the bills that provide a true test of the commitment of members to civil rights. The relevant point to be made here is that the relationship between descriptive representation and substantive representation of black interests is very much tied to the nature of issues. The more divisive the civil rights measure, the greater the likelihood that race will be a factor in explaining legislator behavior on African-American policy preferences.

One way to get a more complete explanation of the role of issues is to break down [tables 12](#) and [13](#) into more discrete data. An examination of specific bills can help shed more light on the significance of issues in congressional voting along racial lines. [Table 14](#) presents the proportion of voting members of the House supporting the LCCR position on the five most divisive bills in the LCCR indexes (see [app. B](#)). The data are displayed according to members' race, party, and regional affiliation for the 100th, 101st, 102d, and 103d Congresses. The findings reveal that black members of the House consistently occupy the Left position (most liberal) of the five groups, followed by white nonsouthern Democrats, southern Democrats, nonsouthern Republicans, then southern Republicans. Given the fact that the vast majority of African-Americans support policies of a redistributive nature, it is not surprising that black representatives would be to the Left of other members in the House. More than this, their position on socioeconomic policies is in accord with the theories proposed on the saliency of race in the House; that is, electoral considerations and a sense of group consciousness among blacks would lead one to expect that black lawmakers would cast their roll call votes in a manner consistent with the liberal policy views of the black masses.

In all cases white nonsouthern Democrats are supportive of the positions endorsed by the LCCR, but they are always to the Right of black representatives. Moreover, the distance between black members and white nonsouthern Democrats is greater on bills in the 101st through 103d Congresses than they are in the 100th Congress. The bills used to compile the LCCR scale during the 100th Congress include the Japanese-American Redress Act (and amendments to it); the Civil Rights Restoration Act (and amendments to it); Hate Crime Statistics Act; Pay Equity bill; Budget Resolution providing for increases in programs for the poor, impoverished children, medical insurance for the elderly and homeless; and the Fair Housing Bill of 1988 (and amendments to it). Of the five bills included in the table the greatest distance between the two cohorts occurs on two Japanese-American Redress bills, legislation designed to provide payments to Japanese-Americans interned during World War II.

The Lungren Amendment to the Japanese-American Redress Act was intended to strike a provision that gave restitution to Japanese-Americans for their hardships during World War II. The bill was opposed by the LCCR and rejected in the House by a vote of 162 to 237.³⁰ Black representatives who voted on the amendment gave their unanimous support, while 89 percent of voting white nonsouthern Democrats supported positions endorsed by the LCCR. The other bill was the adoption of the conference report that authorized payments of twenty thousand dollars in reparations to surviving Japanese-Americans interned during the war.³¹ The LCCR endorsed the report, which was passed by a vote margin of 257 to 156 in the chamber. The proportion of black representatives supporting the bill was 100 percent, and for white nonsouthern Democrats the support

level was 89 percent. The distance of 11 percent is relatively close and is even closer between the two liberal cohorts on votes for the other three most divisive bills in the LCCR index for the 100th Congress. The high levels of support and the close proximity of the two most supportive groups suggest that race was not a major factor.

TABLE 14. The Proportion of House Members Supporting the LCCR Position on the Five Most Divisive Votes in the LCCR Index

	BLK	WND	WSD	WNR	WSR
100th Congress					
Budget Resolution for low-income families	100.0	94.0	89.0	0.0	0.0
Amendment to Japanese-American Redress Act	100.0	89.0	45.0	38.0	12.0
Motion to Civil Rights Restoration Act	100.0	99.0	94.0	12.0	0.0
Adoption of Conference Report to Japanese-American Redress Act	100.0	89.0	41.0	50.0	10.0
Final Passage of Japanese Redress Act	100.0	94.0	44.0	42.0	15.0
101st Congress					
Habeas Corpus Amendment	95.0	78.0	13.0	33.0	3.0
Chapman Americans with Disabilities Amendment	95.0	81.0	23.0	22.0	5.0
Savings and Loan Redlining Amendment	100.0	82.0	30.0	31.0	3.0
Racial Justice Amendment	100.0	90.0	43.0	13.0	0.0
Olin Americans with Disabilities Amendment	95.0	86.0	34.0	27.0	34.0
102d Congress					
Balanced Budget Amendment	92.0	67.0	16.0	2.0	0.0
Unlimited Punitive Damage Amendment to the Civil Rights Act of 1991	96.0	63.0	20.0	2.0	5.0
Race-Based Sentencing Crime Amendment bill	95.0	77.0	26.0	6.0	5.0
Habeas Corpus Crime Amendment bill	95.0	86.0	50.0	6.0	0.0
Voting Rights Language Assistance Amendment	95.0	81.0	47.0	12.0	8.0
103d Congress					
District of Columbia Statehood bill	97.0	64.0	18.0	0.0	0.0
Balanced Budget Amendment	95.0	66.0	21.0	0.0	0.0
Gays in the Military Amendment bill	92.0	68.0	2.0	9.0	0.0
Adoption of Conference Report on Gun Control bill	92.0	78.0	46.0	35.0	23.0
Amendment to Racial Justice Crime bill	97.0	87.0	51.0	6.0	0.0

Note: BLK = black representatives; WND = white nonsouthern Democrats; WSD = white southern Democrats; WNR = white nonsouthern Republicans; WSR = white southern Republicans.

In contrast, there are signs of racial cleavage on bills in the 101st through 103d Congresses. During the 101st Congress (1989–90) bills in the LCCR index included amendments to the Americans with Disabilities Act, Hate Crime Statistics Act,

Minimum Wage Increase, amendments to the Civil Rights Act of 1990, a Savings and Loan Restructuring/Redlining amendment, the Family and Medical Leave Act (and amendments), and amendments to crime bills. During the 101st Congress the greatest distance between the two most supportive groups came on votes for a redlining bill and a crime bill. One of the more controversial bills was a savings and loans restructuring bill initially proposed by Senator Edward Kennedy of Massachusetts.³² The bill was designed to help bank regulators combat the discriminatory practice of redlining used by some mortgage lenders to deny mortgage and other credit to racial minorities. The bill was endorsed by the LCCR and passed in the House by a vote of 214 to 200. The bill received the unanimous support of black representatives who cast roll call votes. The support level from white nonsouthern Democrats who cast a vote was 82 percent. The distance between the two cohorts was 18 percent.

Another illustration is a crime bill offered by Democrat William J. Hughes from New Jersey. The bill was endorsed by the LCCR. Provisions in the bill included, among other things, the requirement of competent counsel for death row prisoners filing federal habeas corpus petitions.³³ Although the bill was rejected in the House by a vote of 189 to 239, 95 percent of the black members who voted supported the bill, as compared to 78 percent of voting white nonsouthern Democrats. Thus, close to one-fourth of voting white nonsouthern Democrats voted in opposition to the position endorsed by the civil rights organization.

Debate over the issue of crime continued in the 102d Congress (1991–92). Two crime bills offered by Republican representative Henry J. Hyde made the list of the five most divisive bills in the LCCR index. The most divisive of the two was a proposal to eliminate a provision in a larger crime bill to allow death row prisoners to raise certain race-bias claims in federal habeas corpus appeals.³⁴ The Hyde amendment was adopted by a vote of 238 to 180. The LCCR opposed the proposal, as did all but one voting member of the black delegation, Republican Gary Franks from Connecticut. In comparison, 77 percent of white nonsouthern Democrats voted in opposition to the Hyde crime amendment. Even though over three-quarters of white nonsouthern Democrats supported the bill, they were still some distance away from the support level of 95 percent given by the black membership.

Race-based crime bills were not the only bills on which differences in voting among the two liberal voting groups can be seen. White nonsouthern Democrats were also some distance away from black legislators on a substitute amendment offered by Edolphus Towns of New York. The amendment would have provided for unlimited punitive damages for discrimination based on factors other than race (e.g., sex).³⁵ The bill was defeated by a vote margin of 152 to 277. The LCCR endorsed Towns's amendment. The only black member to oppose the bill was Gary Franks. Approximately two-thirds (63 percent) of voting white nonsouthern Democrats gave their support to the amendment. The distance between black legislators and white nonsouthern Democrats was fairly wide, at 33 percent.

Other bills included in the LCCR scale for the 102d Congress are Voting Rights Language Assistance (and amendments to it), Family and Medical Leave Act, National Motor Voter Registration, and a constitutional amendment to balance the federal budget. As [table 14](#) shows, some racial cleavage between black representatives and white nonsouthern Democrats can be seen on votes for voting rights language assistance and the constitutional amendment to balance the federal budget.

During the 103d Congress (1993–94) the LCCR index included votes on the Elementary and Secondary Education Reauthorization Act, amendment and final passage of the Family and Medical Leave, National Motor Voter Registration bill, amendment to the Racial Justice Act, District of Columbia Statehood Bill, Balanced Budget Constitutional Amendment, gun control legislation (Brady Bill), Gays in the Military amendment, and bills on congressional compliance, violence against women, and employee protection. The most divisive votes came on bills to admit the District of Columbia into the union, a constitutional amendment to balance the budget, the Brady Bill, gays in the military, and racial discrimination in capital offenses. The distance between black members of the House and white representatives on these bills ranged from 10 percent to 33 percent. The greatest distance between black legislators and white nonsouthern Democrats came on final passage of a bill to admit the District of Columbia as the fifty-first state of the union.³⁶ The bill was rejected by a vote of 153 to 277. The LCCR endorsed the bill and 97 percent of the black congressional delegation gave its support. The only dissenting vote came from Gary Franks. White nonsouthern Democrats were less than enthusiastic about the idea of the District of Columbia becoming a state. Less than two-thirds (64 percent) of those who voted gave their support.

These findings are consistent with the model of voting behavior in this book. It is clear that black representatives constitute the most liberal cohort in the House on class-based socioeconomic issues. This, of course, clearly places them in the high amendment/high final passage category of voting behavior. White nonsouthern Democrats are on the liberal side, but they are outflanked by black members of the House. Furthermore, they are not as consistent as black members in giving high levels of support on policies of primary interest to African-Americans.

White southern Democrats are in the middle of the five groups, but their scores vary more widely than those of the other four groups. On some bills they give high levels of support. During the 103d Congress, for example, 86 percent of voting white southern Democrats supported the adoption of the conference report to require states to allow citizens to register to vote while applying for or renewing a driver's license either at agencies providing public assistance or through the mail. In comparison, 97 percent of black members, 96 percent of white nonsouthern Democrats, 13 percent of white nonsouthern Republicans, and 6 percent of southern Republicans supported the conference report, which was adopted by a vote margin of 259 to 164.

Southern Democrats were more tenuous in their opposition to an amendment designed to delete a provision in a racial justice bill to prohibit imposition of the death penalty if a criminal defendant could show racial discrimination. The bill was rejected by a margin of 212 to 217. The LCCR opposed the bill, as did 97 percent of the black delegation. The opposition score for white southern Democrats was in the moderate range, at 51 percent. Eighty-seven percent of white nonsouthern Democrats, 6 percent of white nonsouthern Republicans, and no southern Republicans voted in opposition to the bill. In contrast to their position on adoption of the "motor-voter" registration bill, white southern Democrats were opposed to

granting statehood to the District of Columbia. As [table 14](#) reveals, only 18 percent of the white southern House Democratic delegation gave support to the legislation. In sum, these examples give further support for the contention of policy deviation in the voting behavior of white southern Democrats. They do vote less conservatively than they did four decades ago, yet they are a good distance away from the consistent liberal roll call voting behavior manifested by black legislators.

Republicans are to the Right of Democrats on black policy preferences. In all cases southern Republicans are the most conservative. All things being equal, when it comes to opposing strong civil rights measures, Republicans are generally close-knit.

What are we to make of the findings in [table 14](#)? The evidence reported in this section points to two general conclusions. First, black representatives do a better job of representing the policy interests of black constituents than do white nonsouthern Democrats. Yet it is also true that the distance between the civil rights support scores of black representatives and white nonsouthern Democrats is not great, all things being equal. In substantive terms this means that the trade-off between gaining a black representative instead of a white nonsouthern Democrat will be relatively small. If one compares the mean civil rights support scores of black representatives to those of white nonsouthern Republicans, it becomes readily apparent that the policy distance between the two cohorts is substantial. As a consequence, blacks will reap the greatest policy benefits if a change in representation occurs, if a black Democrat replaces a Republican in the non-South. But, if gaining a black Democratic representative instead of a white nonsouthern Democrat means increasing the probability of a white nonsouthern Republican winning in an adjoining district, then the overall quality of substantive representation for black citizens may be adversely affected by the trade-off.

Second, the findings in [table 14](#) point strongly to Hall and Heflin's argument that the race of the member matters mostly in the South, where blacks historically have been underrepresented in Congress.³⁷ On controversial black interest legislation the magnitude of the policy distance between black representatives and white southern Democrats is fairly substantial and is even greater between black representatives and white southern Republicans. But it is also the case that the drop-off in representation of black interests is substantial if the district moves from representation by a white Democrat to a white Republican in the region. Thus, the picture is less clear about the overall policy implications of increasing black congressional representation in the South—that is, if it is at the expense of a white southern Democrat.

More will be said about the potential trade-offs between descriptive representation and substantive representation in the next chapter. The major focus of this chapter is on the impact of the race of the representative on black policy preferences, and the evidence presented here indicates that the race of the member does matter in congressional voting. But further testing is needed on this important topic before more can be said about the relationship between race and representation.

The Impact of Race (101st–103d Congresses)

Having examined some of the issues in each of the individual congresses in time period 4, the hypothesis that the impact of the race of the member is conditioned by the controversial nature of bills becomes testable. Again, because of the high collinearity between the race of the member variable and the racial composition variable, the latter was dropped from the model.³⁸ Based on the examination of specific issues in the preceding section, the race variable should be a statistically significant predictor of black policy preferences in the 101st, 102d, and 103d Congresses. Furthermore, the effect of race should be greater on votes during the amending process than on final roll calls.

The results are reported in [tables 15](#) and [16](#). The tables essentially break down the data in time period 4 more discretely into individual congresses. As expected, there are sizable differences between the two parties on social and economic legislation. On average Democratic support is at least five times greater than that of Republican support. Also as expected, House members from the non-South are more supportive of civil rights than are legislators from the South. Regional differences are anywhere from 13 to 23 percent in the four congresses under investigation. Percent urban fails to pass statistical significance in the 100th Congress but does contribute to the explanation of civil rights support in the other three congresses. The findings show that there are measurable differences between the mean scores of party and region. In fact, the smallest gap between the mean scores of party and the mean scores of region in a given Congress is 32 percent (final passage model, 100th Congress). The party, region, and urbanization variables are highly statistically significant at the .000 level. But it is abundantly clear that party is the key variable in explaining black policy preferences.

As for the race variable, it is statistically insignificant in both models for the 100th and 101st Congresses. As for the 100th Congress, this finding is to be expected, since votes on bills were relatively undivisive. The findings also support what Swain (1993) observed in her multivariate analysis of the 100th Congress. For the 102d and 103d Congresses the race variable is statistically significant at the .000 level in the amendment model. After controlling for the impact of party and region, racial differences are significant and range from 10 to 12 percent in the model. Race failed to reach statistical significance in the 100th through 102d Congresses in the final passage model. Moreover, racial differences are not as pronounced in the final passage model as they are in the amendment model, again confirming the hypothesis that voting on amendments is a more demanding test of legislator support for black policy preferences than votes on final roll calls.

The evidence presented in [tables 15](#) and [16](#) indicates that race has an impact on civil rights proposals, but its impact is periodic; in other words, in some years it has a significant impact but not others. A plausible interpretation of this finding is that the impact of race will depend on the nature of the issues, which can vary from Congress to Congress. The results also reveal that the race variable has a stronger relationship with voting on amendments than on final passage.

The investigation shows some evidence of congressional voting along racial lines after other explanatory factors have been controlled for. It could be argued, however, that some of the issues in the LCCR index are tangential to black interests, thus affecting the findings. For instance, legislation pertaining to the Japanese Reparations Act is not directly indicative of black interests. Nor, for that matter, is the amendment pertaining to gays in the military.

TABLE 15. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members' Support for Black Policy Preferences: Regression Estimates for Individual Congresses

Variables	Amendment Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1987-88 ^a			
(100th Congress)	50.863	.753	23.798***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	57.573	.725	25.170***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	62.803	.784	28.625***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	72.096	.845	39.868***
<i>Region (Non-South/South)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	18.831	.244	7.775***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	23.174	.261	9.127***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	16.696	.184	6.798***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	12.666	.136	6.516***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	1.920	.012	.718
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	6.681	.033	1.106
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	12.138	.070	2.508**
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	10.195	.097	4.468***
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	.044	.029	.916
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	.342	.197	6.739***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	.229	.129	4.593***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	.236	.124	5.771***

Note: Per LCCR index.

^a1987-88 ($R^2 = .62$, $N = 398$); 1989-90 ($R^2 = .68$, $N = 412$); 1991-92 ($R^2 = .72$, $N = 394$); 1993-94 ($R^2 = .82$, $N = 426$).

*** $p \leq .001$ ** $p \leq .01$ (one-tailed tests)

TABLE 16. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members' Support for Black Policy Preferences: Regression Estimates for Individual Congresses

Variables	Final Passage Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1987-88 ^a			
(100th Congress)	48.540	.767	24.853***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	46.681	.723	22.820***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	58.512	.784	27.123***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	63.806	.792	32.104***
<i>Region (Non-South/South)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	16.968	.234	7.666***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	15.926	.221	7.014***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	16.233	.193	6.723***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	14.945	.171	6.995***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	3.706	.024	.762
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	.870	.005	.169
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	4.796	.029	1.008
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	7.361	.074	2.936***
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	.029	.021	.676
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	.190	.135	4.172***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	.156	.094	3.183***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	.323	.179	7.190***

Note: Per LCCR index.

^a1987-88 ($R^2 = .64$); 1989-90 ($R^2 = .61$); 1991-92 ($R^2 = .68$); 1993-94 ($R^2 = .76$). See table 15 for *N* of cases.

*** $p \leq .001$ (one-tailed test)

Because some of the votes may not be directly related to black interests, a variant of the multivariate models displayed in tables 15 and 16 is constructed. The reconstructed models drop from the LCCR indices votes that do not directly pertain to the social and economic policy interests of African-Americans. Determining which votes to exclude is open to multiple, qualitatively different interpretations by the analyst. The decision here is to drop votes on the Japanese Reparations bills (100th Congress), American with Disabilities bills (101st Congress), Voting Rights Language bills and the Balanced Budget Amendment (102d Congress), and Gays in the Military bill and the Balanced Budget Amendment (103d Congress).

Tables 17 and 18 present the estimates of the multivariate models. The first observation to be made is the considerable stability of the results across the two different versions of the models. While the magnitudes of the coefficients undergo some change, the essential findings remain the same. What accounts for these findings? A plausible interpretation is that blacks are

consistent in taking the liberal positions on civil rights issues, even if the issues are tangential to black interests. The issue of gays in the military, for example, is not an issue that directly pertains to black interests. Even so, black-white differences can be seen on the issue of gay rights. On a related question, in a 1992 NES survey respondents were asked if they favored laws to protect homosexuals from discrimination. In the case of whites 59 percent favored the law. As for blacks, 70 percent favored protecting homosexuals from discrimination.

Racial differences can be seen in the voting behavior of members on the Meehan amendment (103d Congress) to strike the provision in the Fiscal Year 1994 Defense Authorization Bill codifying a ban on homosexuals in the military. The LCCR endorsed the amendment, as did 92 percent of black members who voted on the bill. In contrast, 68 percent of white nonsouthern Democrats, 2 percent of white southern Democrats, 9 percent of white nonsouthern Republicans, and no southern Republicans cast their votes for the bill. In essence the inclusion of tangential bills in the LCCR index does not significantly alter the results in this chapter.

Discussion

Proponents of descriptive representation argue that the quality of substantive representation for blacks will improve if more of them are elected to serve in Congress. This assumption is based upon the notion that questions of race have political implications. As a consequence, most civil rights leaders look to the number of people of color in Congress to assess its representativeness. There is a theoretical basis to support their assertions, which can be found in the social science literature on group consciousness and representatives’ political perceptions of their constituencies. The first view posits that strong feelings of group attachment brought on by shared historical and life experiences can influence the substantive legislative activities of black lawmakers. In the words of black congressman Louis Stokes of Ohio, “We’re carrying the load for 25 million black people.”³⁹ Those words infer a sense of group consciousness among black members of Congress that transcends the boundaries of constituents in their congressional districts. The second view holds that legislative behavior will be influenced by representatives’ perceptions about who will optimize their chances for reelection. Thus, there is a strong theoretical basis for hypothesizing that African-American representatives will be most responsive to black interests.

TABLE 17. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members’ Support for Legislation More Reflective of Black Interests: Regression Estimates for Individual Congresses

Variables	Amendment Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1987-88 ^a			
(100th Congress)	52.332	.761	23.802***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	62.650	.759	27.266***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	62.763	.779	28.176***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	76.858	.872	43.253***
<i>Region (Non-South/South)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	16.958	.216	6.806***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	22.201	.241	8.705***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	16.727	.184	6.708***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	10.291	.107	5.388***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	1.524	.009	.278
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	8.360	.041	1.450
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	12.071	.069	2.500**
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	8.682	.080	3.873***
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	.010	.002	.896
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	.290	.161	5.670***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	.247	.138	4.902***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	.179	.091	4.471***

Note: Per LCCR index.

^a1987-88 ($R^2 = .61$); 1989-90 ($R^2 = .70$); 1991-92 ($R^2 = .71$); 1993-94 ($R^2 = .84$). See table 15 for *N* of cases.

*** $p < .001$ ** $p < .01$ (one-tailed tests)

TABLE 18. Effects of Party, Region, Race, and Urbanization on House Members' Support for Legislation More Reflective of Black Interests: Regression Estimates for Individual Congresses

Variables	Final Passage Model		
	Unstandardized	Standardized	t-ratio
<i>Members' Political Party</i>			
1987-88*			
(100th Congress)	50.418	.788	25.799***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	55.692	.748	24.659***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	59.869	.800	28.418***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	51.124	.766	29.034***
<i>Region (Non-South/South)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	14.603	.199	6.594***
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	18.368	.221	7.327***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	14.016	.166	5.944***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	10.928	.151	5.774***
<i>Race (Black/White)</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	2.307	.015	.474
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	1.624	.009	.286
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	3.242	.020	.698
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	6.898	.084	3.105***
<i>Percent Urban</i>			
1987-88			
(100th Congress)	.009	.007	.229
1989-90			
(101st Congress)	.209	.128	4.150***
1991-92			
(102d Congress)	.167	.101	3.497***
1993-94			
(103d Congress)	.288	.193	7.240***

Note: Per LCCR index.

*1987-88 ($R^2 = .65$); 1989-90 ($R^2 = .64$); 1991-92 ($R^2 = .70$); 1993-94 ($R^2 = .73$). See table 15 for N of cases.

*** $p \leq .001$ (one-tailed test)

Using data from eleven congresses coupled with an examination of bills in the more recent congresses, the analysis here finds evidence for the hypothesis that race matters even after controlling for the strong impact of party and region. These findings indicate that it is misleading to state or infer that race is a nonfactor in legislative voting on issues of primary interest to the black community. As the results reveal, the significance of race as a predictor of black policy preferences will depend on the nature of the bills.

By now it should be clear that the two major political parties are polarized on class-based socioeconomic issues. The complaint that there is not a "dime's worth of difference" or that the two parties play Tweedledum and Tweedledee does not apply to roll call voting on civil rights. The evidence presented here suggests that the race of the member will matter most when the Democratic Party holds a slim majority of the seats in the House, all things being equal. Because the parties are more united in opposition to each other than at any time since World War II, each party is more dependent on its own members for votes. Within the Democratic Party this translates into greater bargaining power for the Black Caucus, which can

use its leverage to bargain successfully for more social programs of importance to its constituents. Conversely, the caucus will have little influence in a Congress with a Republican majority because of its small Republican membership and the fact that black constituents are not a major component of the electoral coalition of Republican candidates.

While the two parties are clearly polarized on issues of primary interest to African-Americans, there are some important internal differences with the Democratic Party on civil rights legislation. All things being equal, black representatives are the most supportive of black interests, followed by white nonsouthern Democrats. While both are in the high final passage/high amendment category, on balance there is a good deal of space between the two groups on some important issues. The variation in the support level of white nonsouthern Democratic support gives more credence to the hypothesis that race matters in the decision calculus of the representative.

Racial differences in congressional voting are much more pronounced in the South, where the proportion of blacks in the House is low relative to the proportion of the regional population. Some success has been made in this area as the result of the 1990s round of redistricting, which brought in a record number of black representatives to serve in the 103d, 104th, and 105th Congresses. Even so, representation of blacks is still not comparable to the proportion in the region. The analysis indicates that researchers should exercise caution when interpreting the voting behavior of white southern Democrats. While southern Democrats are less conservative than they were three decades ago, on average they are some distance away from the support levels of black representatives or nonsouthern Democrats.

There are reasons to believe that the findings in this chapter may underestimate the effects of member race. This statement is based on an important observation made by Hall and Heflin regarding the censoring of civil rights proposals by the party leadership in Congress. As they rightfully point out, the types of policies most African-Americans would like to see enacted into law lie far to the Left of the median voter in Congress. This is especially true of congresses in which the Republican Party holds a majority of the seats. With the data in [table 14](#) in mind, consider the following example. Suppose that there is a normal distribution of voting preferences on civil rights proposals in the House. Now suppose that black representatives are on the far Left (most liberal), followed by white nonsouthern Democrats (liberal), southern Democrats (moderate), nonsouthern Republicans (conservative), and southern Republicans (most conservative). Assume also that the Rules Committee and leaders of both parties censor civil rights proposals before they are considered on the floor. If the gross assumption can be made that they censor civil rights proposals with the thought in mind of winning enough votes on the floor for passage, then many liberal proposals will not be considered for floor action because they are likely to be defeated, because of a lack of majority support on the floor of the House. If liberal proposals do come up for a vote on the floor, they will likely produce cleavages along racial lines in the legislative chamber. More important, one is likely to see the emergence of member race as a predictor of roll call voting behavior on black interest legislation.⁴⁰

The findings presented here have potentially important political consequences. There is more to the election of African-Americans than symbolism or the color of skin. The color of Congress has implications for the quality of substantive representation for African-Americans. The high level of support among black lawmakers is unmatched by any other cohort in the assembly. Civil rights advocates have long argued that the racial composition of Congress and districts significantly affects the quality of representation for blacks. As a consequence, they have called for legal remedies to enhance the electoral fortunes of black congressional candidates. The course of action sought most often to elect more blacks to legislative assemblies has been benign racial redistricting, a subject for analysis in the next chapter. Their efforts have met with some success, as a record number of black representatives were elected after the 1990 round of redistricting. But in the wake of *Shaw v. Reno* (1993), *Miller v. Johnson* (1995), and *Bush v. Vera* (1996), which question the merits of reapportionment based on race, recent gains made by blacks through racial redistricting may be temporary. At the very least those who are interested in increasing the number of historically underrepresented racial minorities in Congress should take some comfort in knowing that opponents cannot deny the importance of color in Congress based on substantive reasoning.